

Chapter 92_2 - Su Mo

Outside the door was dusk. The distant green mountains were hazy in outline, and nearby the blue water reflected the sky. A wooden bridge extended into the gently flowing river.

Her lack of warmth toward people remained unchanged. Ning Fuyi touched her chest again, putting on a frail appearance as she lay down, her lips pale: "It's already getting dark outside. My injury hasn't healed yet. If I leave like this, there might be danger."

"Since the young lady saved me, could you help me with one more favor? Let me stay here for two days. Once my chest doesn't hurt so much, I'll leave immediately!" She tried to widen her eyes to make herself appear gentler.

Su Mo¹ frowned and pointed toward the door again. Seeing her so firm, Ning Fuyi simply rolled her eyes, went limp, fell sideways on the bed, and closed her eyes without moving.

Seeing this, Su Mo hurried forward two steps and carefully placed her hand on Ning Fuyi's pulse, her eyes flickering.

Perhaps due to suffering countless humiliations since childhood, she had always been very guarded against people, not believing there were good people in this world. Saving this woman's life earlier was only out of compassion, unable to bear seeing a woman faint in the wilderness.

But unexpectedly, she had still brought trouble upon herself.

She only hoped this person truly just wanted to recover from her injuries and would really leave after two days.

Thinking this, Su Mo withdrew her hand, picked up the bowl beside her, turned and stepped out the threshold, closed the door, and left by the fading daylight.

When the wind from closing the door lifted the hair at her forehead, Ning Fuyi reopened her eyes, exhaled, sat up, and placed a sound-barrier formation on the door.

"Han Ya, Jiuying." She coldly tossed out the prayer bead, and the two who had abandoned her in their panic fell before her. Han Ya stumbled and nearly toppled over, while Jiuying maintained some dignity, holding the unconscious Bai Lin in her arms and smiling awkwardly at her.

"After being a Demon Lord for decades, your skill at lying has certainly improved." Jiuying elegantly arranged her hair.

Meanwhile, Han Ya bounced over to the window to peek out, looking rather disappointed: "This is the Divine Venerable's reincarnation? She seems rather strange and unlikable, with no immortal bearing at all, nothing like a deity."

"I've always heard Master mention the Divine Venerable at night. I thought she'd be someone of exceptional celestial beauty." Han Ya spoke thoughtlessly without a heart.

"Han Ya." Ning Fuyi spoke. "She is mortal in this life after all. Besides, how can you speak of her like that?"

Han Ya quickly covered her mouth.

Seeing this, Jiuying coughed twice to draw Ning Fuyi's attention and smiled: "The Divine Venerable is indeed difficult to approach in this life. Do you still plan to stay here?"

Hearing this, Ning Fuyi looked toward the dim light outside the window and nodded: "She had parents in this life. Even though both parents are dead, she shouldn't be so guarded. She must have suffered much in the past."

"Moreover, I came down precisely to protect her soul. Chu Qingqiu made countless enemies in her lifetime. If I can find her soul, others might be able to as well. So staying by her side gives me peace of mind." Ning Fuyi said indifferently.

The initial joy of finding her had faded. Now, looking at this corner of the mortal world, she felt more like she was in a dream.

Su Mo—she wasn't Chu Qingqiu, yet she was also Chu Qingqiu.

Jiuying nodded: "But even if you want to stay, I see the Divine Venerable has quite a fiery temperament in this life. How can you make her relent within two days? That depends on your fortune."

Ning Fuyi blinked and slowly extended her divine sense to search for Chu Qingqiu's traces.

She was in the smaller bamboo house next door. This wooden courtyard had only three rooms in total—one occupied by her, another containing simple kitchen utensils and a mud-brick stove, and the last one obviously used for storing miscellaneous items, cramped and small.

Chu Qingqiu—no, Su Mo—was now huddled in that cramped room. She was too frugal to light an oil lamp, only using moonlight filtering through cracks in the broken wall to spread out a grass mat, then wrapping two hemp ropes around the half-rotten door latch.

Watching her so seriously wrap the hemp ropes, Ning Fuyi felt somewhat amused, but more than that, her nose began to sting.

Just how afraid must she be to have such heavy defenses?

The woman didn't remove her veil even before sleeping, but lay down fully clothed on the grass mat. Though her eyes were closed, her eyelids trembled lightly—clearly she didn't dare truly fall asleep.

Ning Fuyi couldn't bear to watch anymore and withdrew her divine sense.

"Jiuying, Han Ya, you should leave first. The prayer bead is stuffy after all and can't be occupied for long. Find lodging in town and wait for my message." Ning Fuyi took out some gold and silver and handed it to them.

"Yes." Han Ya said with pursed lips. Just as she was about to leave with Jiuying, Ning Fuyi called her back.

"You crows all like collecting little trinkets. Do you happen to have any books about sign language? If not, please buy me one."

Han Ya's eyes rolled, then she beamed: "Master asks at just the right time—I actually do have one!"

Saying this, she pulled out a wrinkled mortal book from under her arm and handed it to Ning Fuyi, then transformed into black mist and disappeared.

Only Ning Fuyi remained in the room. She shook the booklet, searched the entire house before finding a half-used oil lamp, and began reading by the bean-sized flame.

She read and read, continuing through the entire night.

It wasn't until the rooster's crow pierced the night sky that Ning Fuyi raised her aching eyes, put away the booklet she had memorized most of, and stretched long and hard.

The oil lamp had long since burned out, leaving only a bare lamp base. She knocked her head with her hand. Whether in her past life or this one, she had always hated memorizing books. Back when she was still at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, she hadn't even wanted to listen to the elders' lectures.

Yet now, because of Chu Qingqiu, she had memorized so many difficult gestures in one night. Truly, fate played tricks on people.

A creaking sound came from outside the window. Ning Fuyi used her fingertip to lift the window and look into the courtyard. In the still-dim morning light, the door of the neighboring bamboo house was pushed open, and the woman in green robes stepped carefully to the water vat in the yard, reaching out to scoop water.

However, there was obviously no water left in the vat. She only scooped out half a ladle to pour into the basin and lowered her head to wash carefully.

She had her back to Ning Fuyi, so even though she removed her veil, Ning Fuyi couldn't see her face. Ning Fuyi had wanted to use her divine sense to investigate, but put down her raised hand.

Since she didn't want to be seen, she shouldn't do such things.

After a while, Su Mo dried her face and covered it again with the veil layer by layer, then stood up and used a stick to carry two wooden buckets, preparing to fetch water from the river.

Compared to her body, those two wooden buckets were really too large, making her whole person sway unsteadily. Ning Fuyi couldn't bear to watch, so she pushed open the door, planning to help her.

But the moment she touched the wooden stick in Su Mo's hands, Su Mo suddenly seemed startled, dropped the buckets and backed away repeatedly. Her overly violent reaction startled Ning Fuyi as well, and she immediately froze in place.

However, behind Su Mo was a rather deep pit. Just as she was about to step into it and fall, Ning Fuyi had to reach out and pull her. This contact made things even worse—Su Mo looked down and screamed. Unable to speak, even her screams were hoarse and harsh.

Such fearful screaming made Ning Fuyi's heart ache like needles. Su Mo somehow produced a gleaming dagger and waved it back and forth. Ning Fuyi simply didn't dodge at all, directly grasping the blade tip with her palm. She released Su Mo with her right hand and used the force of gripping the dagger to pull her back, not letting her fall.

"Su Mo, it's me!" Ning Fuyi spoke in the gentlest voice of her life. Her left hand was bleeding, while her right hand was raised in place, indicating she meant no harm.

The smell of blood awakened Su Mo's reason. She tremblingly opened her eyes, her tear-filled eyes staring incredulously at Ning Fuyi's bleeding hand, finally stopping her constant retreat.

She quickly let go, and the dagger clattered to the ground.

Now Ning Fuyi extended both hands, slowly pointing to the pit behind Su Mo, afraid of frightening her again.

This time Su Mo saw it. She knew she had wrongly accused Ning Fuyi. Her hands clutched her clothing tightly as tears flowed from her jade-like cheeks, falling drop by drop into her veil.

Only then did Ning Fuyi slowly grasp her wrist and pull her away from the spot. The wrist in her palm was soft as clouds but trembling like a sieve, immediately making one's heart ache.

"It's alright now." She said gently.

Footnote:

¹ **Su Mo** (苏陌): The name she uses in this mortal life, meaning "Su of the Paths" or "Su of the Stranger."